Riverfed.

A PRACTICAL TRAINING

The AI Builders Handbook

Agents · Design · Marketing · Business — distilled from builders shipping real products.

25 sources | 6 concepts | 11 topics | 27 entities | Markdown-native

IN ONE SENTENCE

Most decks talk about AI. This one shows you how operators *use* it.

Every claim traces back to a video transcript in `wiki/sources/`.
Verify anything.

The shape of this training

MODULE 1
Foundations
Six mental models that change how you operate.

MODULE 2
Architecture
Why every modern agent is the same shape.

MODULE 3
Build & Operate
From toy demos to production systems.

MODULE 4
Marketing
The vibe-marketing stack, end to end.

MODULE 5
Design & Coding
Taste as the moat.

MODULE 6
Business
$100B companies with <5 employees.

WRAP-UP
What good looks like
The minimum viable AI builder.

MODULE 1

Foundations

Six mental models that change how you operate.

01

The six concepts



01

Terminal as the interface of work

One session: research, design, copy, deploy.



02

Markdown is the oxygen of LLMs

The substrate for context, memory, output.



03

Memory failures are write failures

If the agent forgets, the bug is in the write.



04

Opportunity cost > token cost

Price on value delivered, not spend.



05

Distribution beats engineering

Ship-and-distribute > build-perfectly.



06

Agent-friendly websites

20% of e-commerce traffic by 2030 = agents.

CONCEPT 01

Terminal as the interface of work

The terminal isn't just for engineers anymore

- Research, design, copy, ad creative, A/B tests, deploys — **one session**
- Context, tools, execution converge in one place
- Five independent sources land on this frame
- It's why Claude Code, Codex, OpenClaw all *feel* the same

> *"The terminal is the interface of work."*

— Greg Isenberg, citing the pattern across his entire roster of guests.

CONCEPT 02 + 03

Two markdown rules that compound

Markdown is just text

What most people see: format for blog posts, README files, notes.

- Static, decorative
- One-way: human writes, human reads

Markdown is the agent's oxygen

What operators see: the substrate for context, memory, skills, outputs.

- Live, queryable, append-only
- Round-trip: agent reads → acts → writes → reads again

Corollary: if your agent forgets a correction, the bug isn't in retrieval — it's in *what you wrote*. Fix the write step.

CONCEPTS 04, 05, 06

The economic shift

$150

Token spend for a board memo that beats 4 hours of analyst time.

0×

Marginal cost of one more landing-page variant.

20%

Of e-commerce traffic by 2030 = agents shopping for humans.

The reframe: stop pricing on tokens, start pricing on *value delivered*. Stop building the perfect product, start *distributing* the rough one. Stop designing for human visitors, start designing for the agent reading your site.

CONCEPTS IN THE MACRO

A universal superpower

20×

Programmer productivity Andreessen attributes to AI-augmented builders.

2–4×

Corporate overstaffing — the "AI vampires" slowing the shift down.

$100B

Companies are now plausible with under five employees.

The builder role is collapsing coder, PM, and designer into one operator. The leverage isn't the role — it's the toolchain underneath it.

MODULE 2

Architecture

02

Every modern AI agent is the same shape — and that's the leverage.

What is an agent?

Chat

Question → answer.

One turn. Stateless. You drive every step.

Agent

Goal → loop until done.

Observe → think → act, repeated. Persists between sessions.

> *"Chat is question-to-answer. Agent is goal-to-result."*

The spectrum: chatbot → system

L1
Chatbot
Question → answer. Stateless. You drive every step.

L2
Workflow
Multi-step but fixed. The LLM fills slots in a script *you* wrote.

L3
Agentic workflow
Same script, but the LLM picks which steps to skip, repeat, or revisit.

L4
Agentic system
The LLM defines the goal-state, the loop, and which tools to call.

Pick the level you actually need. Most "agent" projects only need L2 or L3 — labelling them L4 is the over-engineering trap.

Four pieces of every production agent



01

Model

The brain. Opus 4.7, GPT 5.5, etc.



02

Context

`agents.md` + `memory.md`
Role + learned rules.



03

Tools

MCP servers — Gmail, Linear, Stripe, your data.



04

Skills

Markdown SOPs. Reusable procedures.

Master these four files and you can switch harnesses without rebuilding the workflow.

Same engine, different car

Harness	Maker	Best for
Claude Code	Anthropic	Terminal-first, agentic coding
Codex	OpenAI	GUI super-app, docs + sheets + browser
OpenClaw	Open-source	Customizable, runs on your vault
HyperAgent	Airtable	Fleet observability, command-center
Manus	—	Computer-use specialist
GenSpark	—	Emerging super-app

> *"Once you know how to drive, you can jump in any car."*

MODULE 3

Build & Operate

From toy demos to production systems.

03

NATE HERK · AIOS COURSE

The Four C's of an AIOS

C1

Context

What the agent knows about you. `agents.md`, `memory.md`, plus the wiki it queries.

C2

Connections

API endpoints + CLI tools — Gmail, ClickUp, Stripe. Often beats MCP servers on tokens.

C3

Capabilities

Skills — markdown SOPs in `.claude/skills/`. Reusable, composable, agent-readable.

C4

Cadence

Scheduled routines — cloud (laptop off), local (desktop on), `/loop` (in-session crons).

Each layer depends on the one below. No Cadence without Capabilities; no Capabilities without Connections; nothing works without Context.

Onboard your agent like an employee



01

Define

Write `agents.md` — the job description.



02

Wire

Hook up 3 MCPs: search, your data, the action target.



03

Train

Run on real tasks. Correct in `memory.md`.



04

Schedule

Turn the recurring procedure into a skill, cron it.

Cadence: meaningful improvements at 30 / 60 / 90 days. Same as hiring a junior.

THE ARBITRAGE

Persistence is the moat

99% of people one-shot a prompt and quit.

The 1% who use it daily for 90 days are unrecognisable from the 99%.

The capability is the same. The discipline isn't.

30%	Casual-user output quality
90%	Daily-user output quality after 90 days
3×	The gap. From nothing but showing up.

Context engineering beats prompt engineering

Prompt engineering

Clever wording. "You are an expert in..." "Think step by step..."

- Manual every time
- Doesn't compound
- Brittle to model changes

Context engineering

Rich `agents.md` + accumulating `memory.md` + examples folder.

- Load once, leverage forever
- Compounds weekly
- Survives model upgrades

> *"A two-word prompt produces excellent output if `agents.md` is rich."*

NEW TOOLING · SHIPS IN CLAUDE CODE

The fleet dashboard

`claude agents`

Three swim lanes for parallel sessions, native in the terminal.

- **Needs input** — where to focus next
- **Working** — already running
- **Completed** — ready to ship

Spacebar to peek without entering. `/bg` backgrounds any standalone session. Sessions survive dashboard exit and relaunch.

> *"If you don't visually see it, you tend to forget about it."*

— Chase AI, on why visual fleet awareness matters when you're juggling 3–6 concurrent agents.

MODULE 4

Marketing

04

The vibe-marketing stack — end-to-end inside one terminal.

The pipeline



01

Research

Perplexity + Firecrawl + Playwright. Find the competitive gap.



02

Context

Idea Browser MCP pipes ICP, positioning, offer into the agent.



03

Build

Positioning → copy → design → lead magnet → Remotion video.



04

Experiment

HumbleLytics swaps headlines on live traffic. No redeploys.

The full stack in one Claude Code session. Researcher, copywriter, designer, video editor, paid-media buyer, CRO analyst — collapsed into a single agent loop.

JONATHAN COURTNEY · AJ&SMART

The Promoter Blueprint

Four-phase revenue loop

Marketing strategy upstream of tactics.

Most people optimise step 3 (sell). Winners design the loop.

01
Traffic
Organic + paid

02
Holding pattern
Newsletter, podcast, social

03
Selling event
Webinar, campaign, retargeting

04
Conversion
(Non-converters loop back)

Three growth levers most builders ignore



AEO

Answer Engine Optimization

Be cited by Perplexity / ChatGPT / Claude. Monitor with Otterly, Profound. SEO is dying; AEO replaces it.



MCP

MCP as distribution channel

Publish to Smithery, MCPT, OpenTools. Every AI assistant = a 24/7, zero-CAC sales rep.



BUY

Newsletter acquisition

$5–20K acquisitions in niches. Pre-built distribution + warm audience + recurring revenue.

MODULE 5

Design & Coding

Taste is the new moat. Code is the cheap part.

05

design.md — the portable blueprint

The "soul" of a design in one markdown file

- Typography, color, spacing, motion, WebGL
- **Travels across mediums**: web, mobile, slides, motion
- **Travels across tools**: Figma, Framer, Aura, Codex, Claude Code
- New spec adds Tokens, Components, CLI linter for WCAG validation

> ***"Design is no longer about pixels. It's about judgement per minute."***

— Meng To, who ships marketing sites for 4 SaaS products solo using a single design.md.

The new levels of AI coding

LEVEL 0

Autocomplete

Suggests next token. Old Copilot.

LEVEL 1

Chat

Q&A about code. ChatGPT, Claude.ai.

LEVEL 2

In-IDE agent

Reads + edits files in context. Cursor.

LEVEL 3

Autonomous harness

Owns end-to-end tasks. Claude Code, Codex, OpenClaw.

Most builders should operate at Level 3. The autonomy threshold was crossed in late 2025 — pre-threshold mental models are now actively wrong.

MODULE 6

Business

$100B companies with under five employees.

06

The Tiny model — agents in production

132

Portfolio companies
at Andrew Wilkinson's Tiny

$40K

Monthly Claude bill — replacing
multiple ops headcount

2 wks

For a CFO with zero coding
to ship a $50K platform replacement

> *"Support as a job is months away from disappearing."*

CEO = Promoter, not Builder

Old model

The CEO builds the company. Hires, manages, ships features, runs ops.

- Scale by hiring humans
- 10-person team = 10-person output
- Software is the moat

New model

The CEO promotes the company. Picks channels; agents handle execution.

- Scale by hiring agents
- 1-person team = 10-person output
- Distribution + compute are the moats

WHERE TO START YOUR AI AGENT BUSINESS TODAY

The five-step playbook



01

Pick a vertical

Where AI replaces a $1K–$10K/month line item.



02

Build the agent

As an internal workflow first. Get it bullet-proof.



03

Sell as managed service

Not SaaS. $5–20K/month. Opportunity-cost pricing.



04

Scale with agents, not humans

Each new client = clone the agent + customise the context.



05

Park gains in infrastructure

Software moats erode. Compute moats compound.

Autoresearch as a niche business

The pattern

Define a metric. Let the loop iterate. Keep only the winners.

The infrastructure is rented (Colab / Lambda / RunPod). The moat is picking the right niche and defining "better" as a single scalar.

> ***"The bottleneck is judgment, not compute."***

01

Pick a tight niche

Amazon listings · email sequences · SaaS pricing · clinical-trial design.

02

Define "better"

A single scalar — clicks, revenue, conversion, model score.

03

Charge monthly

UX = "press accept, get winners." Recurring revenue with compute as the moat.

The whole training in one line:

Pick one harness. Build one agent. Use it daily for 90 days.
Curate the markdown vault that lives behind it.
Then ship — distribution-first.

Minimum viable AI builder



01

One harness

Claude Code, Codex, or OpenClaw. Pick. Don't shop.



02

One `agents.md`

Your standing role. 200 words.



03

Three MCPs

Search, your data, your action target.



04

Five skills

Your recurring workflows.



05

One vault

Markdown. Everything you learn.



06

One shipped thing

Distribution-first. Not engineering-first.

THE WIKI IS THE TEXTBOOK · THIS DECK IS THE COURSE

Now go build.

25 sources · 6 concepts · 11 topics · 27 entities — all in `wiki/`.